

Practice Paper 9 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “Roughly the same temperature as a slap”

1 mark for identifying that the water was **shockingly cold** / **piercingly cold**; **1 mark** for explaining that the comparison conveys both **suddenness** and **physical pain** — the cold hit her sharply, like a blow to bare skin.

Sample answer: The comparison suggests that the water was **bitingly cold** and that its first contact with her body was **abrupt and painful**, in the same way that a slap is sudden, sharp, and stinging.

Q2. [2] — Reluctance or apprehension in Paragraph 1

1 mark each for any two of:

- She stood with “my arms folded across my ribs” — a defensive, self-protective posture.
- She “tried to remember why this had once seemed a reasonable idea” — implying she now doubts her own decision.
- She describes the eight kilometres as “nothing in particular” / a void to be crossed.
- She “gasped once” before diving — showing fear of the cold.
- She dived only “because there was nothing else for it” — reluctance, not enthusiasm.

Q3. [2] — “A wire goes through clay”

1 mark for identifying the **simile**; **1 mark** for explaining its effect — the cold was **sharp, thin**, and **cut cleanly** through her body, suggesting that it was **invasive and penetrating** rather than merely uncomfortable.

Sample answer: The simile compares the cold to a thin, hard wire slicing through soft clay, which suggests that the cold **penetrated her entire body easily and sharply**, as though she offered no resistance to it.

Q4. [2] — “Half a conversation with yourself”

1 mark — A long swim is as much a **mental challenge** as a physical one; the swimmer must spend hours **alone with her own thoughts**.

1 mark — She must **manage, argue with, or talk down** her own inner voice — her doubts, fears, and tiredness — in order to keep going.

Q5. [2] — The doubt as a “slow leak”

(a) [1]: The comparison suggests that the doubt entered her mind **gradually and quietly, seeping in** drop by drop rather than arriving all at once — making it harder to notice and resist.

(b) [1]: Any **one** of: her shoulder ache “felt less like fatigue and more like warning”; the far shore “did not appear to have moved at all”; the near shore had “become an embarrassing blue smudge”; she was “exactly halfway to nowhere”; the sea beneath her was “sixty metres deep”.

Q6. [3] — Mei as thoughtful and effective companion

1 mark for identifying that Mei is **calm, restrained, and emotionally intelligent**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- Mei “did not ask whether I was all right” — she avoids a question that would force the narrator to lie, showing she **understands her companion’s pride**.
- She “held up a small bottle of warm sports drink on a stick” — she provides **practical help** (fuel, warmth) without fuss.
- She “said, very quietly” — her **tone is low and undramatic**, which steadies the narrator.
- She did not say “you can do it” or “be brave” — she avoids **empty encouragement** / clichés.
- She offered “an arithmetic fact” — she gives the narrator a **concrete, manageable** number, which is more useful than emotion.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “The cold stopped being an enemy”

1 mark — She has stopped **fighting** the cold or **resenting** it; she has **accepted** it as part of her environment.

1 mark — This shows she has reached a state of **calm acceptance** / **mental clarity**, in which her energy is no longer wasted on resistance and she can simply keep moving.

Q8. [1] — “Bargaining”

1 mark: The word suggests that her earlier doubts were **negotiating** with her — offering her excuses to stop, slow down, or quit, as though her mind were **trying to talk her body out of continuing**. It conveys an **internal argument**, not a settled fear.

Q9. [1] — Physical struggle in Paragraph 7

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “My fingers had gone the colour of old wax” (extreme cold and poor circulation).
- She “did not lift my head to check” (she had no energy to look).

- The arm, arm, breathe had become a “kind of prayer” (her movement was now mechanical and desperate).

Q10. [2] — “A small and rather puzzled gratitude”

1 mark — She had **expected** to feel **triumph** / **elation** / a sense of victory at finishing.

1 mark — Instead she felt only a **quiet, almost confused thankfulness** — toward her body, her companion, and the water — which is **more humble** than she had anticipated.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, contemplative, humbled, philosophical, quietly awed**.
(Reject: **sad, triumphant, bitter** — these miss the meditative quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “As much heritage as a temple”

1 mark for understanding **heritage** — cultural inheritance / tradition passed down through generations.

1 mark for understanding the comparison — that a humble street meal can be **as culturally meaningful and historically rich** as a religious or monumental site, despite its modest appearance.

Q13. [2] — Origins of Singapore’s hawker culture

1 mark each for any two of:

- It was inscribed on the UNESCO Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2020.
- It traces back to **itinerant cooks** of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.
- The cooks came from various communities — **Hokkien, Teochew, Tamil, Malay**.
- They set up **portable stoves at street corners** because they **could not afford shopfronts**.

Q14. [2] — “Audible accents of a particular history” (own words)

1 mark — These dishes are **living evidence** / **records** of the past — they **carry the memory** of the communities that created them.

1 mark — They came from people who were **poor**, who had **migrated** to a new place, and who had to **invent** dishes cleverly from limited ingredients.

Reject answers that lift “audible accents” or “ingenious improvisation” without rewording.

Q15. [2] — “Quietly radical”

1 mark — Modern cities are increasingly **divided by income** / class — the wealthy and the working classes rarely share the same physical or social spaces.

1 mark — A hawker centre, where a banker queues behind a delivery rider and pays the same price, is therefore **unusually equal** — it gently **resists** this social separation, even if it does not announce itself as doing so.

Q16. [1] — Inverted commas around “third places”

1 mark: The inverted commas show that this is a **technical term** / **coined term** borrowed from sociology, not a phrase of the writer’s own invention. (Also accept: he is **acknowledging the term’s specialist origin** / signalling that he is **quoting** sociologists.)

Q17. [2] — “Peculiar new threat: prosperity”

1 mark — Normally, threats to a tradition come from **poverty, neglect, or outside pressure** — i.e. when a society cannot afford to keep something.

1 mark — Here, the threat is the **opposite**: it is **wealth itself** — rising rents, tidied-up streets, and better-educated children — that is endangering street food. This is **paradoxical** / unusual.

Q18. [2] — Uncertain future of hawker food**1 mark each** for any two of:

- Vendors have been **cleared from many lanes** in Bangkok since 2017.
- The average age of hawkers in Singapore is now **in the late fifties** (i.e. ageing workforce).
- The **children of stallholders are unwilling to inherit** the business.
- The work involves **eighteen-hour days** and **unrelenting heat**.
- Hawker centres are full at lunch but **their kitchens are quietly emptying**.

Q19. [2] — “Meaning of eating” has changed (own words)**1 mark** — The food itself **tastes the same**, but the **experience** and **social significance** of eating it have become different.**1 mark** — What was once an **ordinary, neighbourhood meal** eaten by locals has, in some cases, become a **tourist attraction** / a **spectacle** / something performed for cameras at a higher price.**Reject** answers that lift “meaning of eating” without explanation.**Q20. [1]** — Tone of “the most awkward to discuss honestly”**1 mark** — Any **one** of: **candid, honest, frank, measured, balanced, thoughtful**. (Also accept: **reluctant but truthful**. **Reject**: **angry, defensive, sarcastic**.)**Q21. [2]** — Effect of the closing two short sentences**1 mark** — The two short sentences **contrast sharply** with the long, balanced sentences before them; this gives the ending a **firm, final, almost declarative weight**.**1 mark** — They place **responsibility on the reader and society** — culture survives only through **deliberate human effort**, not by chance — making the closing line feel like a **moral challenge** rather than a description.**Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]****Content points** (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.****The cultural value of street food (Paragraphs 2–3):**

1. It records the **history of migration** and the **cultural heritage** of immigrant communities.
2. Its dishes were **born of poverty and creative improvisation** by people who could not afford shopfronts.
3. It is a rare **shared public space** where people of all income levels and backgrounds eat side by side.
4. It acts as a **“third place”** that **binds society together** across class divisions.

The threats it faces today (Paragraphs 4–6):

5. **Prosperity** itself threatens it — rising wealth and tidier cities push vendors out (e.g. Bangkok crackdowns).
6. The **workforce is ageing**, and the **children of stallholders refuse to take over** the long hours and heat.
7. **Commercialisation** — Michelin attention, tourism, and food tours — raises prices and replaces locals with camera-carrying visitors, changing the meaning of the meal.

8. **Hygiene regulations**, although necessary, can be **too rigid** and **price out small operators** who cannot afford modern kitchens.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Street food is culturally valuable because it preserves the migration history and improvised cooking of poor immigrant communities, and offers one of the few public spaces where citizens of every income share a table as equals. Today, however, it is endangered by prosperity itself: vendors are evicted from gentrifying streets, ageing cooks have no successors, tourism and Michelin attention inflate prices and transform meals into spectacles, and inflexible hygiene rules quietly squeeze out the smallest, most traditional stallholders.

Length count: 78 words from “Street” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —